

Yellow Shades upon a Global Color Line

Historicizing Filipino America and the “Deadliest Phase of U.S. Imperialism”

MICHAEL VIOLA

In his speech before the First Congress of Negro Writers and Artists in 1956, Frantz Fanon warned against the liberal habit of considering racism as an individual “disposition of the mind, a psychological flaw.”¹ He argued that racist systems of colonial domination breed racist individuals and thus a “colonial country is a racist country.”² Fanon was adamant that racial oppression must be understood as intertwined with the capitalist forces of colonial domination and “[t]his is why military and economic oppression generally precedes, makes possible, and legitimizes racism.”³ He expanded upon the argument that the transformation of individual mindsets can only be sustained through the creation of new societal conditions that facilitate new ways of thinking, acting, and being in his classic text, *The Wretched of the Earth*. Inspired by Fanon’s diagnosis of a specific form of anti-Black racial oppression set forth by French colonial rule in Algeria, I confront another colonial history painted in yellow shades upon a global color line. Utilizing the history of Filipino America as the point of departure, I take the position that the United States is an imperialist country under which the conditions of anti-Asian racism and authoritarianism take root and grow.

Fanon’s invitation for the wretched of all the earth to shed colonial influences of domination was taken up by Filipino scholar, Renato Constantino, who contended that the history of Filipino peoples in the Philippines and dispersed throughout the world had been denied to them. With “little comprehension of our past,” Constantino maintained in *Neocolonial Identity*

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and Counter-Consciousness, "we have no appreciation of its meaningful interrelation with the present."⁴ He contended that if the material conditions of the present are accepted "as given, bereft of historicity," then an entire people will be ill-prepared for the unfinished project of liberation as well as tomorrow's struggles and victories.⁵ As a historian opposed to the systemic processes of colonial "miseducation," Constantino exposed the violent absurdities of U.S. imperialism in the Philippines and, in doing so, influenced many anticolonial intellectuals, including István Mészáros's historical analysis of the imperialist world system.⁶

In *Socialism or Barbarism*, Mészáros contended that imperialism is a constantly evolving historical system with a "jungle-like network of contradictions that can only be more or less successfully managed for some time but never definitely overcome."⁷ In his examination of the fluid dynamics of imperialist relations, Mészáros offered a historical diagnosis of imperialism in three interrelated phases: (1) early modern colonialism, (2) classic imperialism, and (3) global hegemonic imperialism, with the United States as the dominant international force. Published two years before the U.S.-led "War on Terror" in the aftermath of September 11, 2001, Mészáros's thesis is that global capitalism is in structural crisis as it faces a myriad of limitations and contradictions. In addressing such conditions, Mészáros suggests that the historic phase of U.S.-led "global hegemonic imperialism" is the "potentially deadliest phase of imperialism."⁸ As important as Mészáros's analysis of imperialism is, he mentioned racism only once in this text, offering scant analysis as to how racial domination, and, of particular interest, how anti-Asian racism is instrumental to the processes of U.S. capital accumulation. Filling in the gaps of Mészáros's important analysis offers greater historical precision to the character of anti-Asian racism, the way it has reconstituted itself over time, and its entwinement with authoritarian domination hardwired into U.S. imperialism since its inception in the Philippines in 1898.

Divided into four sections, this article begins with an examination of the debates over the status of Filipinos with U.S. colonial expansion into the Philippines at the turn of the twentieth century. This national debate divided the nation into two broad ideological camps: the anti-imperialists and the imperialists, with both undergirded by distinct modes of anti-Asian racism that demarcated Filipinos as "semi-savage others" or "Little Brown Brothers." The second section explores the structural contradictions of classic U.S. imperialism, in which Filipinos were systematically imported into the country as a source of cheap labor from the Great Depression to the aftermath of the Second World War. Yet, their growing presence in America sparked a lingering challenge to the mythos of white

superiority and racial purity, setting in motion a host of authoritarian laws that racially codified Filipinos as “un-American.” The third section analyzes the neoliberal turn of the late 1960s to 2000s, when the United States emerged as the lone global hegemon. During this time, Filipino immigrants were engulfed in a “model minority mythology” at home, while abroad, a model minority reality of U.S. supported authoritarianism was created in the Philippines. Taking into consideration all these historical phases of Filipino America, in the fourth section, I assert that the contemporary realities of immigrant mass detention and the menace of (para) military violence unleashed upon people of color at home and abroad are not simply byproducts of irrational elected leaders, but rather intrinsic features of a U.S. imperialist system in its undeniably deadliest phase.

Becoming “Semi-Savage Other”/“Little Brown Brother”

The theft of native land and African bodies is the foundation of the U.S. capitalist system.⁹ This system was further maintained at the dawn of the twentieth century with the colonization of the Philippines and the birth of U.S. imperialism. The public concerns about the “civil rights and political status” of Filipinos divided the nation into two broad ideological camps: the anti-imperialists and imperialists, with both positions undergirded by distinct modes of anti-Asian racism.¹⁰ The anti-imperialist bloc advanced a pessimistic mode of anti-Asian annihilation that associated Filipinos as the “Semi-Savage Other,” portraying them as backward and uncivilized threats needing to be quarantined from the U.S. body politic. Representing an optimistic mode of racial assimilation, the imperialist bloc viewed Filipinos as savages who could be advanced into “Little Brown Brothers,” so long as they were willing to be molded into junior partners in the advancement of U.S. economic and military interests in the region. These dual modes of anti-Asian racism, which defined Filipino as both “Semi-Savage Other” and “Little Brown Brother,” were not necessarily concrete and bounded but rather complementary and fluid in advancing a terrible violence against the Filipino people.¹¹

While much has been written about the anti-imperialist positions of W. E. B. Du Bois and Mark Twain and their opposition to U.S. colonialism in the Philippines, their positions were not the prevailing sentiment of the time. The anti-imperialist bloc was predominately fueled by a U.S. nativism seeking to protect a white social order from the imaginary hordes of “semi-savage” Filipinos and “objectional races” that would seek incorporation into the United States with Philippine annexation. One of the most instrumental anti-imperialist figures of the period was Samuel Gompers, president of the American Federation of Labor. As a

primary proponent of the Chinese Exclusion Act of 1882, Gompers declared "the superior whites had to exclude the inferior Asiatics, by law, or if necessary, by force of arms."¹² As one of the featured speakers of the Chicago Peace Jubilee organized to commemorate the conclusion of the Spanish-American War on October 18, 1898, Gompers asserted, "If the Philippines are annexed what is to prevent the Chinese, the Negritos and the Malays coming to our country?... Can we hope to close the flood-gates of immigration from the hordes of Chinese and the *semi-savage* races coming from what will then be part of our own country?"¹³

Gompers's anti-Asian sentiments were embraced by a wider population, so much so that it was anticipated that the U.S. Senate would vote against the annexation of the Philippines. However, two days before the Senate vote, a U.S. military command instigated a battle against Filipino nationalists on February 4, 1899, initiating the Philippine-American War.¹⁴

Three days into the Philippine-American War, anti-imperialist South Carolina Senator Benjamin Tillman spoke on the Senate floor. Drawing upon Rudyard Kipling's poem "The White Man's Burden," Tillman condemned U.S. involvement in the Philippines.¹⁵ Drawing on the history of Black enslavement in the U.S. South to support his anti-imperialist position, Tillman proclaimed, "We of the South have borne this white man's burden of a colored race in our midst since their emancipation and before" and because of it the country has witnessed "two races side by side that can not mix or mingle without deterioration and injury to both and the ultimate destruction of the civilization of the higher."¹⁶ Tillman then called for a compromise between imperialist and anti-imperialist positions as he pleaded, "Why not tell these people [the Filipinos].... We only want enough of your territory to give us a harbor of refuge, a naval station, the right to protect you from outside interlopers, and to get such commercial advantages as you of right ought to give us."¹⁷ Tillman's declaration encapsulated the U.S. desires and wider imperial designs in the Philippines, rationalized over time by veiled and not-so-veiled forms of anti-Asian racism.

The debate between anti-imperialist and imperialist positions continued throughout the span of the Philippine-American War. Before his ascension to the U.S. presidency in 1901, Theodore Roosevelt criticized the anti-imperialists by paralleling the "savagery" of Filipinos to North American Indigenous populations. Roosevelt argued, "We have no more right to leave the Filipinos to butcher one another and sink slowly back into savagery than we would have the right, in an excess of sentimentality, to declare the Sioux and Apaches free to expel all white settlers from the lands they once held."¹⁸ Lambasting the anti-imperialists for not recognizing how "Filipinos offer excellent material for the future," Roosevelt continued, "If

our forefathers who came over the seas to settle in the vast wooded wilderness along the Atlantic seaboard nearly two centuries ago had been as timid as those degenerate descendants of theirs who now protest against expansion, this continent would still be nothing but the hunting ground of the red men.”¹⁹ Roosevelt was clear that the extension of U.S. warfare “at the expense of barbarism and savagery” in the Philippines was part of a long-standing race war in “the progress of [White] humanity.”²⁰

Firsthand accounts from U.S. soldiers stationed on the front lines described the systemic annihilation of the Filipino people and the use of racial epithets historically cast upon Black and Indigenous peoples to dehumanize their newly constructed enemies. U.S. military general, William Shafter, confessed, “It may be necessary to kill half the Filipinos in order that the remaining half of the population may be advanced to a higher plane of life than their present semi-barbarous state affords.”²¹ In a letter published by the *Fairfield Journal* of Maine, U.S. Sergeant Howard McFarland was quite clear as to the rationale for why the United States invaded the Philippines. “At the best, this is a very rich country; and we want it. My way of getting it would be to put a regiment into a skirmish line, and blow every n***** into a n***** heaven.”²²

More than six thousand African-American soldiers were sent to the front lines of the Philippine-American War. Wrestling with their own realities as racialized subjects in Jim Crow America, Black soldiers recognized the stark similarities between an anti-Black racial order in the United States and the anti-Asian racism taking shape thousands of miles away. A letter published in 1901 written by William Simms, a Black-U.S. soldier stationed in the Philippines explains, “I was struck by a question a little [Filipino] boy ask me, which ran about this way: ‘Why does the American negro come...to fight us when we are much a friend to him and have not done anything to him. He is all the same as me and me all the same as you. Why don’t you fight those people in America who burn Negroes, that make a beast of you...?’”²³

Despite an indisputable U.S. military advantage, the Philippine-American War lasted much longer than expected. In response to the immense cost and growing unpopularity of the war at home, U.S. colonial decision-making powers shifted from a strategy of military annihilation to one of assimilation.²⁴ A primary means of achieving this was the establishment of an educational system designed to create a Filipino “Little Brown Brother” trained to manage and sustain U.S. colonial efforts without a large occupying force. Under President William Taft, a shipload of teachers aboard the army transport ship *SS Thomas* sailed from San Francisco to the Philippines in 1901 to establish a colonial educational

system.²⁵ Shortly after Taft's decision to pacify the Filipino people with a U.S. education, U.S. soldiers based in the Philippines came up with a marching song that professed, "They say I've got brown brothers here.... He may be a brother of William H. Taft, but he ain't no brother of mine."²⁶

Shortly after the Philippine-American War was proclaimed finished on July 4, 1902, Du Bois identified how U.S. expansion throughout the world fueled a "new religion of whiteness." This religion, according to Du Bois, preached the "divine right of white people to steal" and taught its devotees that "whiteness is the ownership of the earth forever and ever, Amen."²⁷ Anti-Asian racism is a denomination of the religion of U.S. whiteness baptized in the violent expropriation of Philippine land for capital accumulation and the establishment of a military base. With their designation as U.S. colonial subjects, Filipinos entered the country to serve the labor needs of American agriculture, and anti-Asian racism further transformed upon their arrival. Considered neither citizen nor alien, Filipinos were racially codified as "un-American," a label that predated and informed the Red Scare hysteria of McCarthyism, facilitating capitalism's ability to absorb the energies of Filipino labor and disregard their collective life.

Becoming Filipino "un-American"

After the Philippine-American War, there was incessant resistance to the U.S. colonial project in the Philippines.²⁸ In the United States, domestic agribusiness anticipated further Asian exclusion policies that would threaten their labor force and in response the Hawaiian Sugar Planter's Association (HSPA) pressured the federal government to facilitate the entry of Filipinos to work the fields. In Hawai'i between 1909 to 1914, Filipinos became nearly twenty percent of Hawai'i's plantation labor force.²⁹ The moment they arrived, Filipinos organized to improve their material conditions. A historical case in point was the organizing efforts of Pablo Manlapit and the Filipino Labor Union (FLU) in Hawai'i.

Born in the Philippines on January 17, 1891, Manlapit signed a contract to work on a Hawaiian sugarcane plantation in 1910 when he was only 19 years old. Two years after arriving in Hawai'i, the HSPA placed Manlapit on a blacklist due to his involvement in a strike campaign that unified Japanese and Filipino plantation workers. In 1919, Manlapit became president of the newly formed FLU. Under his leadership, one of the union's first campaigns was to forge solidarities with Japanese workers. On April 3, 1920, rank-and-file members participated in a public parade to raise greater awareness of their efforts to increase wages, mandate eight-hour workdays, and improve working conditions. A crowd of approximately

three thousand Japanese and Filipino workers marched alongside their families and allies, carrying posters that proclaimed, "We Want to Live Like Americans" and "We are NO Reds.... We are Brown workers who produce White Sugar."³⁰ The *Honolulu Star-Bulletin* described the demonstration as "several thousand alien Asiatics parading through the streets with banner[s] flaunting their hatred of Americanism and American institutions."³¹ This parade would set the stage for the Hawaiian Sugar Workers' Strike of 1920, which was initiated by 2,600 Filipino laborers and in a short time would grow to include 77 percent of Hawai'i's entire plantation workforce, bringing sugar production on the island to a standstill.

To quell this expression of labor solidarity between Filipino and Japanese workers, HSPA president John Waterhouse highlighted the strikers' foreign origins and described their organizing activities as "an anti-American movement designed to obtain control of the sugar business of the Hawaiian Islands."³² Local newspapers echoed Waterhouse's language exhorting that the HSPA should not compromise or back down from the "alien agitators" because doing so would promote "a deadly invasion of American sovereignty in Hawaii."³³ The characterization of Filipino labor organizers as un-American "alien agitators" invading the country from within became a dominant narrative that facilitated the expansion of an antiradical surveillance state. To address "a powerful, potential, and masked enemy in our midst," the U.S. Military Information Division stationed in Hawai'i sent telegrams to the U.S. mainland describing Manlapit in particular as "the most intelligent and most dangerous radical Filipino in the world," who was fueling a "general unrest, financial losses and anti-American feelings" and called for the deployment of "more white troops" to contain the labor unrest.³⁴ While the Hawaiian Sugar Workers' Strike concluded in December 1920, ongoing labor campaigns continued for years, reaching a violent crescendo when the HSPA shipped funds and weaponry to "special deputies" to put an end to the unrest.

On September 9, 1924, vigilante sharpshooters and police were called in to address a peaceful protest led by the FLU. The coordination of paramilitary and state police resulted in the shooting of unarmed protesters that killed sixteen Filipino workers and wounded many more. Coined the "Hanapepe Massacre," the Associated Press described the slaughter of peaceful workers on that day as follows: "twenty persons dead, unnumbered injured lying in [the] hospital, officers under orders to shoot strikers as they approached, distracted widows with children tracking from jails to hospitals and morgues in search of missing strikers—this was the aftermath of a clash...[on] Tuesday at Hanapepe, island of Kauai."³⁵ Authorities used this incident as a pretense to incarcerate more than one hundred Filipino workers

deemed to be threats to the established social order. During the sentencing of fifty-six organizers, the presiding judge took the opportunity to castigate the efforts of the FLU as both "dangerous and un-American."³⁶

The worldwide economic downturn of the Great Depression that began in 1929 and lasted until the Second World War was an especially violent period for Filipino workers in California. On October 24, 1929, a mob of three hundred white men in Exeter, California, stormed a Filipino camp, then stoned and clubbed fifty Filipino workers and burned down the barn. In January 1930, the city of Monterrey passed municipal anti-Filipino resolutions that declared, "we do not advocate violence but we do feel that the United States should...send those unwelcome [Filipino] inhabitants from our shores that the white people who have inherited this country for themselves and their offspring might live."³⁷ Within weeks of the resolution's passing, Filipino laborers were terrorized on the streets of nearby Watsonville, California, culminating in the death of Fermin Tobera, who was shot in the heart as a mob of approximately two to five hundred white men destroyed the Filipino workers' housing quarters.³⁸

Fanning the flames of anti-Filipino hysteria, a coalition of sugar planters, conservative politicians, xenophobic civic organizations, and a reactionary white labor movement lobbied the federal government to pass a catalogue of anti-Asian legislation, such as the Tydings-McDuffie Act of 1934. The Tydings-McDuffie Act set a timetable for Philippine independence after ten years with the precondition that the United States maintain neocolonial control over the country's political and economic autonomy. The act also authorized the United States to retain its military bases on the island with the right to control the Philippine military for so-called U.S. defense purposes. Along with establishing a neocolonial relationship with the Philippines, one of the most significant aspects of this act was to redefine Filipinos in the United States as "foreign nationals," subjecting them to immigration quotas that limited the number of Filipinos allowed entry into the United States to fifty per year. A year later, the Filipino Repatriation Act of 1935 was passed with the intention of systematically deporting Filipinos residing in the United States.

It is this social milieu that informed the writings of Filipino organic intellectual and labor organizer, Carlos Bulosan (1913–1956). Bulosan wrote the semi-autobiographical classic, *America Is in the Heart*, and he described the experience of being Filipino in the United States in this way: "I feel like a criminal running away from a crime I did not commit. And the crime is that I am a Filipino in America."³⁹ In his writings, Bulosan perceived the incipient character of American fascism unfolding around him as bound to anti-Asian structures of U.S. militarism and neocolonialism in the Phil-

ippines.⁴⁰ In his essay, "Freedom from Want" Bulosan proclaimed: "We are fighting where the bullet is crashing upon armorless citizens, where the tear gas is choking unprotected children. Under the lynch trees, amidst hysterical mobs. Where the prisoner is beaten to confess a crime he did not commit. Where the honest man is hanged because he told the truth."⁴¹

Bulosan understood that the anti-Asian racism impeding the collective life of Filipinos in the United States was entwined with the U.S. neocolonial project in the Philippines. For Bulosan, it was the duty of the intellectual and writer to contribute their creative works to a larger counterforce needed to stunt the growth of a U.S. security state apparatus that codified "un-American" subjects and sanctioned their widespread criminalization, deportation, and repression.

The racial codification of Filipinos as "un-American" both preceded and informed the state apparatus of McCarthyism and its authoritarian afterlife. Two of the most notorious pieces of U.S. legislation that conflated non-citizenship with criminality were the Smith Act of 1940 and the McCarran Act of 1950. In tandem they were foundational for the infamous activities of the House Un-American Activities Committee. The Smith Act mandated the registration and fingerprinting of all non-citizens or "aliens" residing in the United States during the early part of the Cold War period. This legislation also criminalized political dissent, limited democratic freedom and expression, and enforced an ideological conformity during a time of perceived national insecurity in this country. Shortly after the Smith Act was passed, U.S. post offices throughout the country were turned into processing sites to register the nearly five million non-citizens, as well as those affiliated with leftist organizations.

Described as "deadlier than the Smith Act," by scholar Carole Boyce Davies, the McCarran Act was passed a decade later at the end of the Second World War.⁴² Its provisions included immigration checks, measures for enhanced state surveillance of individuals involved in "un-American" activities, and the ability of the federal government to systematically detain individuals during times of an "internal security emergency." The power of "preventative detention" granted by the McCarran Act was informed by the prior internment of Japanese Americans, allowing the Justice Department to hold Asiatic "un-Americans" and suspected communists, radicals, and fellow travelers in detention camps. This legislation was passed during a time of military intensification throughout Southeast Asia as U.S. imperialism sought to contain the spread of communist threats in Asia after the Chinese Communist Revolution and the outbreak of the Korean War, with the Philippine islands strategically positioned as a staging ground for U.S. military forces.

As the neoliberal turn took hold in the late twentieth century, the United States became the dominant international force throughout the globe, and anti-Asian racism would morph and walk on two legs. In the United States, anti-Asian racism stood on the leg of a "model minority" mythology that masked the historical and global structures of racial oppression. In the Philippines, anti-Asian racism stood on the leg of a model minority reality where U.S.-favored autocrats were propped up to advance policies that benefited the parochial interests of U.S. military-industrial complex and monopoly-finance capitalism.

Becoming Filipino "Model Minorities"

In the midst of the Vietnam War, American sociologist William Petersen coined the term "model minority" in his *New York Times Magazine* article, "Success Story, Japanese American Style," published in 1966, to highlight the success of Japanese Americans, who, despite adversarial conditions, managed to achieve high levels of academic and professional success in this country.⁴³ Petersen highlights the experience of Japanese Americans who he describes as "law-abiding alien residents" taking on employment opportunities that required "menial tasks with such perseverance that they achieved a modest success" as an exemplar for other racialized groups to follow.⁴⁴ The narrative of a model minority became an ideological tactic of white supremacy in the aftermath of the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 to discredit the "problem minorities" who were organizing against U.S. wars and in favor of Indigenous self-determination and Black Power. It did this while advancing a dominant narrative that success in the United States was attainable through peaceful compliance, assimilation to U.S. market values, and hard work.

Touted for remedying the racist national origins quota of past U.S. immigration policies, the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 was a form of state selection that allowed immigrant entry into the country for those with professional training and college degrees deemed beneficial to "the national economy, cultural interests, or welfare of the United States."⁴⁵ This legislation facilitated immigrants, coming primarily to the United States from Asia, who held advanced degrees. As a result, a middle-class stratum of immigrants from the Philippines, along with their U.S.-born children, became increasingly more visible across the country and within institutions of higher education. During the period between 1960 to 1980, the Filipino immigrant population in the United States increased from 105,000 to 501,000. A segment of politicized Filipino American youth, especially in the San Francisco Bay Area, organized for Ethnic Studies under the banner of the Third World Liberation Front, while others began to

internalize the narrative that anyone could make it in this country—so long as they abided by a “pull yourselves up by your own bootstraps” mentality. The mythology of the model minority helped to distance Filipino Americans from other racialized student and youth activists, as it shifted the blame for the impoverished plight of Black communities on their perceived dysfunctional family norms and deficient cultural initiatives. In a succinct distillation of the anti-Blackness seared into the model minority syndrome, Vijay Prashad asks: how can Asian Americans “live with ourselves as we are pledged and sometimes, in an act of bad faith, pledge ourselves, as a weapon against black folk?”⁴⁶

Analysis of the model minority myth connected to the Immigration and Nationality Act of 1965 helps clarify the changing demographics of Filipinos in the United States. Yet, without a global perspective, the myth of the model minority alone frames the racial oppression of Filipinos in the U.S. “metropole” as entirely separate from the history and ongoing project of U.S. imperialism in the Philippine “periphery.” To develop a more satisfactory account of anti-Asian racial oppression, especially with the emergence of a neoliberal world order, a wider frame is required that considers a model minority reality of U.S.-favored autocrats installed in the Philippines. In doing so, we see how authoritarianism is not anomalous to, but rather an intrinsic feature of, U.S. imperialism.

By the late 1960s, the capitalist world system was in deep crisis as anticolonial and nationalist movements throughout the Global South began to democratize the private assets and natural resources controlled by former foreign occupiers and multinational corporations. Against such threats, David Harvey, in his *Brief History of Neoliberalism*, maintains the “capitalist world order stumbled toward neoliberalization as the answer through a series of gyrations and chaotic experiments,” with a primary laboratory being Chile in the aftermath of the U.S.-backed military coup in 1973.⁴⁷ While Harvey’s analysis of the neoliberal turn is significant, it is important to recognize that the events in Chile were not the opening salvo in the U.S. experimentation with the neoliberal state. The neocolonial relationship between the United States and the Philippines served as a beta test for the neoliberal world order. In this arrangement, a model minority of authoritarian elites were propped up to support a global division of resources and asymmetrical exchange that served the narrow interests of U.S. military and multinational corporations at the expense of the life chances of a Filipino majority.

In his role as an observer at the historic Bandung Conference in 1955, author Richard Wright made the astute observation that the Philippines was in an “awkward position” among the non-aligned Asian and African countries

representing the interests of half of the world's population. Wright noted how the Philippine delegation had "to carry water on both shoulders, [where they] would have to talk Right to keep faith with Washington and to act Left to prove that she [the Philippines] was still free in her heart and understood the language of her disinherited Asian brothers."⁴⁸ The head of the Philippine delegation at Bandung was Carlos Romulo, who coordinated extensively with the U.S. State Department to infuse the conference with ideological positions that opposed the "Bandung Spirit" of Third World solidarity and self-determination. Even though the United States was not invited to participate at the conference, they utilized Romulo as a "Free World asset" to promote the ideas of free market, foreign aid, and military strategies that were beneficial to the geopolitical interests of the United States during the Cold War period.

Romulo received a U.S. colonial education, first in primary school from the U.S. Thomasites and later as a graduate student at Columbia University through the Pensionado program. Romulo was an officer in the Philippine military during the Second World War and served as a diplomat under eight Filipino presidents spanning the period of 1950 to 1984. Throughout his tenure, Romulo was a reliable junior partner of U.S. interests in the region, including the use of the Philippines as a military outpost and training ground for U.S. wars in Korea and later in Vietnam, as well as CIA covert operations in support of a right-wing military regime in Indonesia. When Ferdinand Marcos declared martial law from 1972 to 1986, Romulo served as a key spokesperson defending the dictatorship's authoritarian practices and human rights abuses in the global arena. Specifically, during this fourteen-year period of authoritarian rule, the Marcos regime had unwavering support from U.S. Democratic and Republican elected leaders who closed their eyes to Marcos's antidemocratic practice of imprisoning political opponents without warrants, torturing activists without mercy, and disappearing civilians without cause.

The moral and material support of the Marcos regime is indicative of a global world order the United States had fashioned through the installation of comprador states in the Global South who willfully or coercively cooperated with U.S. imperial interests.⁴⁹ During Marcos's dictatorial reign, the Philippines became one of the largest recipients of military aid and high interest loan packages from international institutions like the World Bank and International Monetary Fund in Southeast Asia. Accessing such high interest loans came with specific conditions, such as reorienting the natural resources of the Philippines for global export and carrying out structural adjustments to the local economy that prioritized debt repayment and massive cuts

of government spending on education, health care, and other essential services. The consequences of such neoliberal edicts were drastic and widespread for the Filipino people.⁵⁰ By 1985, it was reported that anywhere from two-thirds to three-fourths of some 54 million Filipinos were poor, with up to half of the population facing extreme poverty.⁵¹ Meanwhile, Marcos, along with a model minority of U.S. autocrats, derived immense personal wealth from U.S.-sponsored loans.

Faced with high unemployment and social unrest in the country, the Marcos dictatorship carried out an economic development strategy that systematically exported Filipino labor all over the world as Overseas Filipino Workers.⁵² The systemic exportation of a Filipino labor force continues to the present day, consisting predominately of women. It exposes these overseas workers to unsafe and captive working environments in their host countries, super exploitative wages, and immense emotional hardship related to family separation. As the Marcos dictatorship exported a significant portion of the Filipino population abroad, he offered multinational corporations with a highly policed and cheap labor force, enticing the relocation of entire industries to the Philippines so that foreign capital could take advantage of nonunionized wages.

U.S. support of the Marcos dictatorship came not just through economic aid but also military support. During Marcos's rule, the U.S. military was able to utilize the Subic and Clark military bases in the Philippines for its wars of aggression in Vietnam and to prevent the influence of China from spreading in the region. In a context of nationwide civil unrest on the islands, the United States supplied the Marcos regime with weaponry, tear gas, and training that shielded a "model minority" of authoritarian leaders from the country's popular and oppositional forces. On a diplomatic visit to New York on July 12, 1980, Romulo, serving as Marcos's Minister of Foreign Affairs, responded to media concerns about widespread human rights abuses in the Philippines, including the extrajudicial killings and disappearances of pro-democratic activists. Romulo distributed a primer to the media members that proclaimed a greater "balance has been achieved between individual rights and the demands of law or of authority" in the Philippines. In response to the question, "Is the Marcos regime repressive?" Romulo clarified: "authoritarian, yes; repressive, no."⁵³

As anti-Asian racism inside the United States masked the historical structures of racial oppression with a model minority mythology, globally, it was also able to hide in the imperial abstractions of joint military exercises, structural adjustments, and so on, made possible by a model minority of U.S.-supported comprador authoritarians in the Philippines. Today, the neoliberal world order, with the United States as global hegemon, is no

longer. To modify Antonio Gramsci's famous remark in a contemporary context of emerging multipolarity with the American Empire in sharp decline, a neoliberal world has died and another world is struggling to be born – and this interregnum is marked by monstrous U.S. imperialism.⁵⁴ Audre Lorde's proclamation of what was needed during the global ascent of the neoliberal world order in 1985 holds true today. "When we do not recognize the ways in which we are connected, we take part in each other's oppression. For me to be involved with what is happening to women in the Philippines...is not an altruistic move. It is a basic issue for each one of us of our survivals."⁵⁵

Becoming Filipino Americans

How we remember the problems of our collective history will inform the ways in which we confront the atrocities of the present. Without a historical consciousness, we run the risk of mistaking the symptoms with the root of the problem. For instance, during the dark days of 2020–2021, when public anxieties about the causes and consequences of COVID-19 were directed toward Asians, with U.S. politicians at the highest seat of power calling the novel virus, the "Kung flu" and the "Chinese virus," the Center for the Study of Hate and Extremism at California State University, San Bernardino, reported a 164 percent increase in anti-Asian violence nationwide.⁵⁶ Reports of violence against Asian-American elders and Asian health care professionals throughout the nation were all too common, escalating with the vicious murder of eight people – six of whom were women of Asian descent – in Atlanta, Georgia, on March 16, 2021. Another case worth mentioning that occurred a month prior to the tragic shooting in Georgia was that of Noel Quintana. A Filipino American, Quintana was riding the New York subway on a busy morning commute to work when a man began to harass him and consequently slashed his face with a box cutter from one cheek to the other. As Quintana bled on the subway floor, no one came to his aid. He explained, "I asked for help, but nobody helped. Nobody moved.... I was scared because I thought I was going to die and nobody helped me."⁵⁷

In response to the nationwide violence, a broad umbrella of community organizations, activists, and local municipalities rallied around the call to "Stop Anti-Asian Hate." The primary means to "Stop Anti-Asian Hate" was the circulation of social media posts and physical posters that touted the multifaceted identities of Asian Americans; public awareness campaigns that encouraged the reporting of crimes to authorities; and calls for greater police presence in Asian-American enclaves. Consequently, the strategies to "Stop Anti-Asian Hate" were largely dissociated from

the history of U.S. military and colonial interventions in Asia and the capitalist exploitation of Asian bodies. As a result, the dominant strategies to "Stop Anti-Asian Hate" reproduced what Fanon warned us against and what was alluded to in the opening paragraph of this essay: the evasion of U.S. military and economic imperialism that generally makes possible and legitimizes anti-Asian racism.

The problems we currently face operate at a much deeper and historical level than individual attitudes and outlooks. Filipino scholar E. San Juan called on Filipino Americans to remember who they are and, more importantly, who they seek to become are not matters "of wish-fulfillment or mental conjuring."⁵⁸ For San Juan, becoming Filipino American is a "collective political project" that necessitates an understanding of "the historical phenomenon understandable neither as Filipino alone nor American alone but as an articulation...of the two societies with their distinct but intersecting histories."⁵⁹ Accordingly, becoming Filipino American comes with the power, the praxis, and the price of a unique lineage that stretches back to the Philippines. Grappling with a U.S. history that has long denied and too often justified Filipino racial subjugation provides greater clarity to the barbarism of our times, exposes historical antecedents, and reveals how the troubles we face are not simply the doings of unhinged elected leaders.

U.S. imperialism in its most current phase is frantically seeking its survival through gunboat diplomacy, threats of annexing foreign lands, and further dragging the Philippines into a New Cold War with China. The existing apparatus for such global maneuverings historically directed toward the foreign other is rapidly being turned inward on U.S. populations, undocumented or otherwise, as we witness the mass detention, disappearance, and destruction of people of all colors. It was Fanon in *Wretched of the Earth* who captured the idea that the peculiar characteristic of fascism is "colonialism at the very heart of traditionally colonialist countries."⁶⁰ The basic issue for each one of us to survive will depend on the people's undoing of a global structure of capitalist accumulation that fuels the forces of anti-Asian racism and authoritarianism. Fortunately, there exists a vibrant and living history of Filipino Americans who have contributed to such a project that we can excavate and bring into the present as we respond to the appeals of Fanon that "each generation must out of relative obscurity, discover its mission, fulfill it, or betray it."⁶¹ Constantino was optimistic in succeeding generations and their ability to draw from the wellsprings of memory to fulfill their collective mission to not just rediscover the history of Filipino America, but more importantly to recreate it—as he reminded us that an abundant and "real people's history is still in the future."⁶²